
Elon Musk Has His Own Encyclopedia Now. Well, We Read Some of the Entries ...

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A hallucinating encyclopedia may not be exactly what you're looking for when you're doing research, but that's what writer [Stephen Harrison](#) found when he dug into Elon Musk's new A.I.-powered [Grokikipedia](#).

"It's definitely not, like, an alternative encyclopedia," Harrison said. "It's got a lot of flaws."

Harrison's area of expertise is Wikipedia. So it's possible he's biased here, but his criticisms are not small ones. I asked Harrison to pull up Elon Musk's [Grokikipedia page](#). It is very, very long. But if you dig in, you'll find some lines that are really telling. Grok portrays the Tesla CEO through stubbornly rose-colored lenses. While Grokikipedia notes Musk's social media leadership has been scrutinized, it also says criticism of him has come from "legacy media outlets that exhibit systemic left-leaning tilts in coverage."

On a [recent episode](#) of What Next, host Mary Harris spoke to Harrison about how the emergence of Grokikipedia is a symptom of something else entirely: a right-wing project to rethink truth altogether. This transcript has been edited and condensed for clarity.

Mary Harris: Is Grokikipedia just a vanity project for Elon Musk?

Stephen Harrison: It's hard to figure out what Grokikipedia actually is. In some ways, there has been a lot of discussion about bias on Wikipedia. I wonder if Elon Musk sensed an opening and thought, "Well, I could take what we have from Grok." Wikipedia's information is available under a Creative Commons license—it's freely licensed. He maybe saw the idea of an A.I.-generated encyclopedia and wanted to be first to market.

Why does the internet need a Grokikipedia? There's already a Wikipedia.

I'm not sure that it does. The broader narrative here is that the far right is attacking all kinds of our traditional institutions, whether that's academia, journalists, and now Wikipedia, and the thinking is that by deprecating the trust that people have in Wikipedia, they can point towards their own user-generated content, or Elon Musk can kind of put out his own narrative.

One of the funny things about Elon Musk creating his own A.I. version of Wikipedia is that Elon Musk was a fan of Wikipedia not that long ago, right?

Back in 2017, Elon Musk tweeted, "I love Wikipedia, keeps getting better and better." You couldn't be more direct, right? In 2022, five years later, is when I really started to see a shift. He said that it's "Wokepedia." He offered to buy it for \$44 billion. That led to all of the donor ads saying, "Hey, Wikipedia is not for sale. We're an independent nonprofit."

A big part of the shift was the representation of himself on Wikipedia. He really did not like the word *investor*. He tweeted about that several times. He asked Wikipedia editors to remove the word *investor*. He sees himself as a thought leader and a visionary, and he really wanted that word removed.

Basically, he wanted to take the Twitter approach. He didn't like what was going on, so he

wanted to buy it. But that wasn't possible.

It's funny. He hates the word *investor*, but that's his move. He buys it.

What do we know about the popularity of Grokipedia, this new site he's created? Is it legitimately a competitor for Wikipedia at this point?

I don't think so, and there are a couple of reasons. Just even on X, I see a lot of blowback to Grokipedia. And I think of X as a place where a lot of Elon's most vocal supporters tend to post. But they're saying, "Hey, I've identified a lot of errors. This page is very lengthy, but it's got meaningless A.I. slop in it." People are saying that it reads like a LinkedIn page, which would make sense because it's pulling from user-generated content as opposed to the more traditional news media sources.

And we know now that when a large language model is trained on A.I.-generated content, it has what's called "model collapse," and it ultimately really suffers. So there's a real concern here for Elon Musk that if his Grok is trained on Grokipedia, then that could lead to the collapse of Grok.

Is it sort of like a mimeograph, where the more you copy it, the fuzzier the image gets?

Yes, it gets more and more fuzzy, and it gets more and more of these hallucinations because it's just predicting what it thinks you want and not what's actually based on an original source text.

I guess I hadn't really realized how political encyclopedias could be.

I think an encyclopedia reflects a worldview, or aims to. It's making a claim on neutrality, right? Like, this is a neutral point of view. It's trying to present information accurately. And people who do not like that accurate, curated version that appears on Wikipedia, they're going to be angry about that. So, anybody who's making a claim that what they're working on is accurate is automatically in the firing line.

Ultimately, any government that is trying to control information, they want the universities, they want national news, they want news media, and then they want Wikipedia.

One thing I've noticed during Trump 2.0 is that some parts of the internet seem more robustly democratic than others. Like, if I look at Reddit, if I look at Wikipedia, to me what's happening there seems muscular and driven by human beings. But then I look at Twitter and Facebook, and they've swung in these extreme ways, politically. What do you think of these more robust sites, if you agree that's what they are—what do they share?

A big piece of it is that they have a higher purpose. Wikipedia editors, when they're acting at their best, they really do believe that there's something more than partisan politics—and that's the accurate reflection of reliable sources. That higher purpose can bring together people of different politics.

One of the things I'm trying to make clear in my reporting is that Wikipedia is not a political monolith, one way or the other. I certainly know Wikipedians who are conservative. There's a lot of discussion about Gen Z men. Well, they're the ones sometimes that are sending me Signal messages and are very active on Wikipedia. So, it's just a fake narrative that's being pushed by Elon Musk and others that Wikipedia is a bunch of liberals. It's just not true.

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